



Moolah Kicks: Women's Sneaker Brand

Case Study

This case was written by **J. Shalom Jenifer** and reviewed by **K. Bhagyalakshmi**, Amity Research Centers Headquarter, Bangalore. It is intended to be used as the basis for class discussion rather than to illustrate either effective or ineffective handling of a management situation. The case was compiled from published sources.

© 2024, Amity Research Centers Headquarter, Bangalore.

Website: www.amity.edu/casestudies/

No part of this publication may be copied, stored, transmitted, reproduced or distributed in any form or medium whatsoever without the permission of the copyright owner.



Author: J. Shalom Jenifer

Moolah Kicks: Women's Sneaker Brand

Case Study

"Moolah is putting out a new future and a new way to look at women's basketball, which is: This is our game, it's unique, and this is what we bring to the table."

– Natalie White, Founder and CEO, Moolah Kicks

Natalie White (White) grew up in New York City and completed her degree in finance at Boston College in 2020 (**Exhibit I**). She had played in the premier basketball AAU¹ circuit and had also witnessed the fierce games played at city parks and playgrounds. White found that the sneakers she and her teammates were wearing was not designed with their needs in mind. White's research revealed that many of the basketball shoes labelled as women's footwear by popular brands like Nike, Under Armour, and Adidas were models that was designed for male foot mold but incorporated traditionally feminine colorways.

Exhibit I

Natalie White – Founder of Moolah Kicks



Source: Raggs Tramel, "Women's basketball shoes often aren't made for women. This company is changing that", <https://www.washingtonpost.com/sports/2023/06/08/moolah-kicks-womens-basketball-shoes/>, June 8th 2023

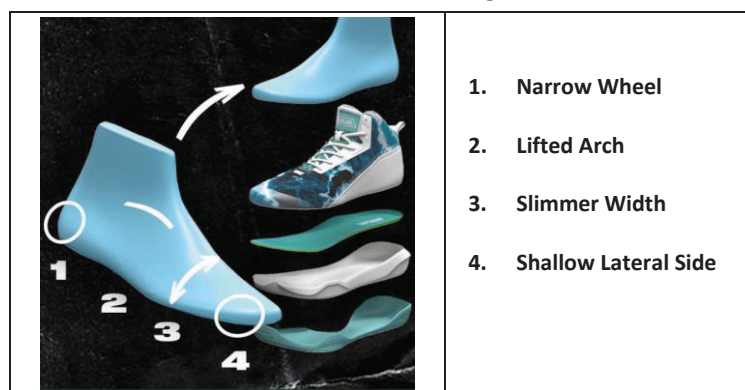
White was aware of the gender inequalities in the athletics industry. She was displeased with Women's National Basketball Association (WNBA) players being used as brand ambassadors promoting men's basketball shoes and wanted to change that dynamic. White explained "for many years the message has been women can become the best players, but they don't deserve their own shoe." Players frequently wore sneakers and men's athletic clothing. White found that there was lack of quality sneakers for female basketball players. With that

¹ Amateur Athletic Union consists of teams of players from 3rd to 12th Grade (Boys & Girls).

realisation, White wanted to make the best sneaker for women and consulted 'orthopaedists, athletic trainers, physical therapists and players at the high school, college and professional levels'.

In 2020, White launched the brand Moolah Kicks (Moolah). After designing the model for women, she tested the products in the basketball court to ensure the shoe was fitting and performing well. Experts emphasised the unique anatomical and biomechanical differences between male and female bodies (**Exhibit II**). They suggested that ensuring proper shoe fit not only minimised injuries, but also tailoring the footwear to accommodate the specific characteristics of female anatomy could enhance stability. It also lowered the impact forces experienced by female basketball players. According to Dr. Elizabeth Gardner, head athletics orthopaedic surgeon at Yale University, 'women had different physical support needs for footwear. Increased stability is most important'. Women basketball players were more likely to tear their ACL² compared to male.

Exhibit II
Moolah Kicks' Design



Source: Compiled by the Author From – "Moolah About us", <https://moolahkicks.com/pages/our-story>

Moolah Kicks had distinguished itself by forging its own path and established the brand as the one and only performance brand specifically tailored for female basketball players. It was designed by sportswear designer Elizabeth McGarry, and included 'a compression set, mesh kit, and signature warmup jackets and pants'. It was available at 450 Dick's Sporting Goods store nationwide. The brand secured endorsement agreements with professional female basketball players and partnered with over 60 college-level NIL³ athletes. 'National Basketball Association (NBA) players like LeBron James, Kevin Durant, or Stephon Curry, the Women's National Basketball Association's (WNBA) Courtney Williams (Williams)' chose to sport Moolah Kicks. It was designed by footwear designer Jon Morris, who was known for designing Reebok's Shaq's shoe. "I never even thought about how a woman's foot is different from a man's, but it's like, duh, of course they are, It drew me in," said Williams, who played guard for the Chicago Sky.

White encountered a doubt and disbelief in her initial pitches. Certain investors expressed concerns about the ambitiousness of her projections and high costs involved. There were doubts about the existence of a viable market for a basketball shoe designed specifically for females. White proved the skeptics wrong and Moolah Kicks had expanded rapidly through

² Anterior Cruciate Ligament was a tissue that connected the thigh bone to the shinbone, at the knee. Most ACL injuries occurred during certain sports such as basketball, football, skiing and tennis.

³ NIL referred to the use of an athlete's name, image, and likeness through marketing and promotional endeavours. It described the means through which college athletes were allowed to receive sponsorship.

'word-of-mouth, social media interaction, and growing support from Dick's'⁴. "We saw a brand, and a founder, who shared in our commitment to provide premium performance products for female athletes. We signed an exclusive distribution deal with Moolah in 2021 and since then, we've more than doubled their in-store footprint", said Carrie Guffey, SVP softlines merchandising at Dick's. Dick's had also invested in Moolah Kicks through DSG Ventures, an internal fund.

In 2021, Phantom 1, the company's first model was launched after working with 'trainers, physical therapists, and industry leaders' to engineer the product. White said, "After developing Moolah's first shoe in 2021, the Phantom 1, I cold emailed the CEO of Dick's Sporting Goods, which ultimately led to Moolah Phantom 1 in more than 140 Dick's Sporting Goods stores across the country. That season was the creation of the first ever women's basketball section in the landmark retailer." As of 2024, the shoes were available at 500 Dick's Sporting Goods Stores in women's basketball section. Moolah, other brands, and athletes turned activists were leading the way in ensuring that women in sports had equal opportunities. White said, "Seeing female hoopers go into Dick's and realize that there's an entire women's basketball section, where they now have options and when they realize there are women's basketball sneakers, and then they are excited to be playing the game— that's what drives us." She added "We're going to continue to listen and serve women's basketball through performance products built specifically for women. We're going to continue to drive innovation in products to elevate women's performance. And we're going to continue to drive opportunities and growth across all levels of women's basketball."

Moolah introduced the Press Break, a basketball footwear line designed specifically for girls from third grade through high school. Moolah focused on both durability and stability. White said, "With this new line we are able to have young female players in sneakers that fit their feet earlier. A lot of the feedback we were getting was there is a demand for having these sooner. With Press Break we will have girls starting out their career in shoes made specifically for them with a brand committed specifically to the future of their game and women's basketball at large. They can play their entire career in sneakers that fit their feet."

White continued to focus on female basketball players and launched Neovolt Pro basketball shoe in 2022. White said, "When we started, we were the first and only women's basketball sneaker—but more importantly, [the only such] brand on the market." She added, "Moolah has gone from a shoe to a movement. It's been really incredible. I think that it's because of the women's basketball community. We are a grassroots company. To say we're built by and for female ballers goes so much deeper." Women's sports had grown outside of the realm of athletics. It had extended to other facets of the sports ecosystem. Moolah's sales grew 112%, while store distribution had increased to 221% in 2023 compared to 2022. It had improved and doubled its sales volume. Distribution of Moolah grew by 200% YoY and gross revenue increased by 150%. According to White, Moolah must be at the forefront of consumers' minds to benefit from these seasonal markets. For this reason, the company used an omnichannel strategy that combined 'paid digital advertising and grassroots or one-on-one marketing with basketball players' to maintain brand recognition.

⁴ Dick's Sporting Goods, Inc. was an American chain of sporting goods stores founded in 1948 by Richard "Dick" Stack. the largest sporting goods retailer in the United States. Dick's professionals not only lend financial support to fledgling companies and expanding enterprises, but they also impart knowledge across a wide range of topics, including as operations, supply chain, distribution, and customer interactions.

Moolah's target audience included high school and collegiate athletes due to the untapped female youth basketball market. It was during this stage they developed their connection to sneakers. White highlighted on the need for more female-focused marketing strategies in the sporting business as well as a shift in how women's basketball was portrayed and endorsed. She questioned the effectiveness of advertisements that featured top female basketball players endorsing sneakers named after male athletes. White suggested brands to concentrate on the female market which could facilitate collaborations between players and brands to create signature lines. Ray Solano, the chiropractic sports physician for Georgetown and Howard basketball, said that addressing women's needs within the shoe industry is long overdue. "I think it's a great development because as it stands, women lack that specificity that they need in supporting their feet." Would Moolah sustain in the sports industry with its women's sneaker brand?

References:

- i. D'arcangelo Lyndsey, "This basketball shoe brand is becoming the Air Jordan for women and girls", <https://www.fastcompany.com/90970121/moolah-kicks-sneakers-air-jordan-womens-basketball>, October 24th 2023
- ii. Raggs Tramel, "Women's basketball shoes often aren't made for women. This company is changing that.", <https://www.washingtonpost.com/sports/2023/06/08/moolah-kicks-womens-basketball-shoes/>, June 8th 2023
- iii. Moneuse Emma, "Moolah Kicks Fights Gender Inequality in Sports With a Pair of Shoes", <https://www.missionmag.org/moolah-kicks-fights-gender-inequality-in-sports-with-a-pair-of-shoes/>
- iv. White Natalie, "A Revolution In Women's Hoops Starts With The Right Sneakers", <https://www.sportico.com/business/commerce/2023/womens-sports-business-independence-moolah-kicks-1234712188/>, March 16th 2023
- v. Tim Newcomb, "Women's-Specific Basketball Sneaker Brand Moolah Kicks Launches Girls-Specific Design" <https://www.forbes.com/sites/timnewcomb/2023/09/15/womens-specific-basketball-sneaker-brand-moolah-kicks-launches-girls-specific-design/?sh=6069ffb549fb>, September 15th 2023
- vi. York Alex and Hasan Zoya, "How This Under 30 Sports Founder Is Changing The Women's Basketball Shoe Industry", <https://www.forbes.com/sites/alexnyork/2023/12/15/how-this-under-30-sports-founder-is-changing-the-womens-basketball-shoe-industry/?sh=438c325d2e26>, December 15th 2023
- vii. Richardson Aran, "Mark Cuban-Backed Moolah Kicks Reducing Women's Basketball Player Injuries With Shoes Designed For The Female Frame", <https://finance.yahoo.com/news/mark-cuban-backed-moolah-kicks-174053298.html>, September 18th 2023